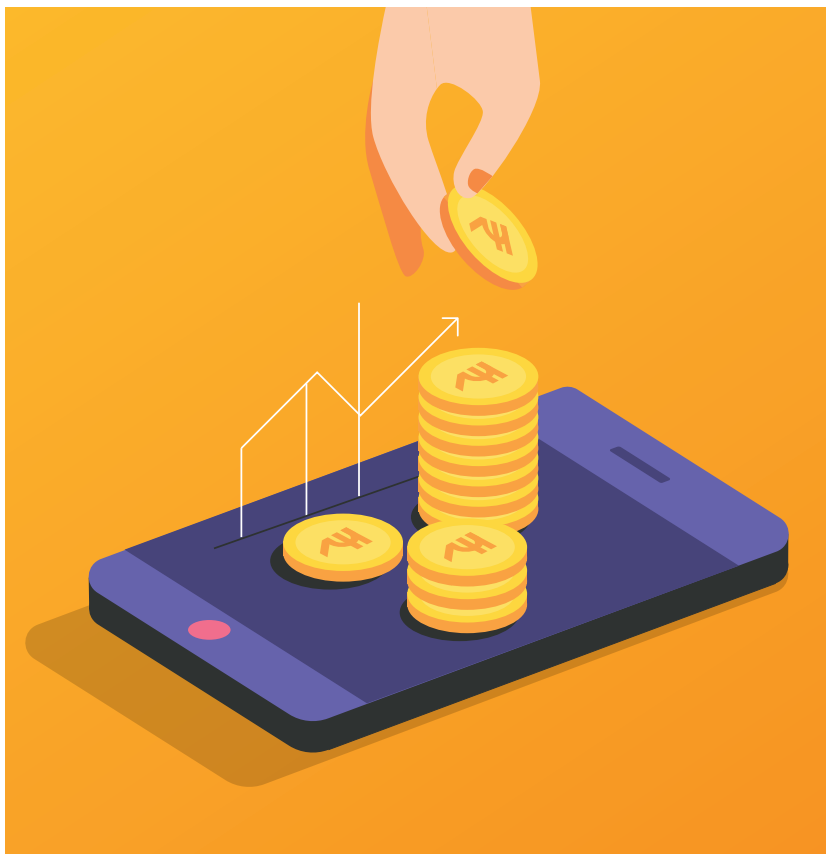




Refurbished phone sales to grow in 2026

As smartphone prices hike, Indian consumers will demand better value deals

Bhaskar Sharma | editor@digit.in

It is no surprise that smartphones are getting pricier across every category, whether it be budget, mid-range, or flagship. The main reason behind this is the global shortage of memory chips, which has pushed up manufacturing costs. Recent phone launches clearly show that the recently launched models

either cost more than before or have cut corners on specifications so that they can stay affordable. If the brands continue to struggle with the supply chain problems, buyers will only have limited value-for-money options. Moreover, if the smartphone prices keep climbing the way they are, many people may start looking at refurbished or second-hand phones

instead, as they are more affordable while offering many of the same features as new devices.

So, are we moving towards a trend where potential buyers may end up preferring a refurbished phone over a new one? Read on for some interesting insights.

Smartphone prices are climbing across the market

The Indian smartphone market is expected to see another round of price increases in 2026. According to Tarun Pathak, Research Director at Counterpoint Research, more than 85 per cent of existing smartphone models have already seen a price hike. On average, prices have increased by around 15 per cent, with some devices expected to become nearly 20 per cent more expensive in the coming months.

The impact is even sharper for newly launched smartphones. Compared to their predecessors, many new models are priced 30 to 40 per cent higher. As a result, the buyers planning to upgrade could end up spending significantly more than they would have a year ago.

Refurbished could become a stronger choice

Tarun believes that rising smartphone prices driven by higher memory costs are expected to accelerate the shift towards refurbished and second-hand smartphones, particularly in price-sensitive markets like India.

He said that 'as the cost of new smartphones continues to increase, refurbished devices are becoming a more compelling value proposition.' According to him, 'some consumers who were considering a new Android smartphone may opt for a refurbished iPhone at a similar price point, while others are likely to choose a refurbished Android device that offers better specifications or features within the same budget.'

Pathak adds that both Apple and Android brands are likely to benefit